

I cannot remember my mother

SUMMARY

The poem, 'I can't remember my mother' has been written by an Indian prolific writer Rabindranath Tagore. The poem is about the sensitive feelings of the child. In this poem the poet expresses his inability to actually recall the face or the features of his mother. But often a smell or a tune triggered off in him happy moments that he shared with his mother as a child. He remembers all the things that his mother used to do. When he looks at his play things, he seems to be able to hear a tune; perhaps his mother often sang the same song as she rocked his cradle. His mother would use shiuli flowers for the morning service at the temple. So, the powerful fragrance of the flowers would trigger off happy memories of his mother. He can recall the quiet serene gaze of his mother when he looks at the vast expanse of the clear blue sky. The simple verses of the poem eloquently reveal the deep seated emotional bonding that the poet had with his mother.

Q1. What is the poet doing when he remembers his mother?

Ans: The poet remembers his mother when he is playing with his toys.

Q2. In what ways does the poet feel the presence of his mother?

Ans: The poet feels the presence of his mother through tune that he hears while he is at play, the smell of shiuli flowers in early autumn that his mother used to carry, his mother's gaze when he stares into the sky while sitting by the window in his bedroom.

Q3. What does the poet hear when he is at play?

Ans. While at play, the poet hears a tune that his mother used to hum while she rocked his cradle to make him sleep.

Q4. What word do we use for cradle song?

Ans: The word we use for cradle song is called 'Lullaby'.

Q5. Is the poet's mother dead or alive? How do you come to know about it?

Ans: The poet's mother is dead, The poet is missing her badly and he cannot remember her face. The poet refers to his mother's activities in past. He feels his mother gazing at him when he looks at the sky. All these things indicate that his mother is dead.

Q6. What sights and smells remind the poet of his mother?

Ans: The sight of the clear blue sky and the smell of Shuili flowers remind the poet of his mother.

Q7. What are the feelings that this poem arouses in you?

Ans: The poem, though simple, is powered with emotions. It is an expression of sensitive and intense emotions on part of a child who has lost his mother. The poem arouses the feelings of pity, sympathy, love, fear and a lot of other feelings among the readers. We feel pity and sympathy for the poet while at the same time the poem arouses feelings of love for our mother and we fear that we may lose our mother someday and it would be hard to live in the world without her.

Literary Devices:

Imagery used in the poem:

Visual: Blue sky

Sound: The humming tune of the cradle song

Smell: Shuili flowers as the scent of the poet's mother